THE ASSASSINS

SIVARASAN (33): The mastermind

He has been one of the most elusive fugitives in history. He had a reward of Rs 15 lakh on his head but made sure he wasn't caught alive. He managed to flee from a hideout a day—just hours, really—before the tracking team arrived. He found eleven LTTE boys who resembled him and got them to hang around in different parts of Tamil Nadu wearing different make-up. So 'Sivarasan' would be seen as a Muslim cleric, a Catholic priest, a bald Hindu priest and a turbaned Sikh to send the sleuths off in the wrong direction.

And when he ran out of hideouts in Tamil Nadu, Sivarasan escaped sitting inside a water tanker and travelled 350 km to Bangalore, crossing a dozen police checks without being caught. When he found that the police had surrounded his hideout in Konanakunte, he didn't immediately die by suicide. He knew the agencies would like to catch him alive, and yet he waited thirty-six hours for them to finally break into his hideout. It's only then that he shot himself through his temple. He was cunning, ruthless, brutal and devoted to his Tamil cause.

He was the one to crack the assassination plan and direct its execution. He used several aliases, of which Sivarasan and Raghuvaran were the most widely known. As per a report by D.B.S. Jeyaraj, first published in *The Hindu* and later in several other publications, Sivarasan's comrades called him 'Ottraikkannan', a one-eyed person, since he had lost an eye. Later, the Indian media referred to him as 'One-Eyed Jack' from a Marlon Brando film.

According to Jeyaraj's report, Sivarasan's real name was Chandrasekharampillai Packiachandran. He hailed from Udupiddy, a town about 32 km from Jaffna city and not far from the hometown of Prabhakaran and the cradle of Tamil armed militancy. He was the LTTE's